

HIV and Healthy Aging

What older adults need to know about treatment, health, and support

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 With early diagnosis and consistent care, people with HIV can live long, healthy lives.



1. WHAT YOU NEED TO KNOW



HIV can destroy your immune system (body's defense mechanism) if left untreated.¹



It can progress to AIDS or increase chances of contracting other infections such as tuberculosis, hepatitis, or STIs.²



HIV does not target only certain groups, such as sex workers, racialized people, or those who inject drugs.



HIV can infect anyone: people ages 13 to 64 should be tested.³



In Canada and the U.S., more than 50% of people with HIV are older than 50 years of age.



This is due to ART (antiretroviral therapy), which is effective in treating HIV.¹



Because of modern medicine, people live longer and healthier lives, even with HIV.⁴



AIDS (acquired immunodeficiency syndrome): the most advanced stage of HIV infection, when the immune system is severely weakened.

HIV (human immunodeficiency virus): a virus that attacks the immune system.

STI (sexually transmitted infection): an infection that can spread through sexual contact.

2. HOW HIV PROGRESSES AND HOW TREATMENT HELPS

1 Acute HIV infection

- HIV-like symptoms may occur.
- HIV grows quickly in the body.
- Many people may not know they have HIV.⁵



Early testing helps protect your immune system.

2 Chronic HIV

- There may be few or no symptoms.
- HIV stays in your body in the long term.
- ART can help people stay healthy for many years.⁶

Viral load = the amount of HIV in the blood
Treatment lowers viral load.



3 3. AIDS (advanced HIV)

- The immune system becomes severely weakened.
- Risk of serious infections becomes higher.
- Consistent treatment can help prevent progression to AIDS.⁷



 Consistent ART helps control HIV and can prevent progression to AIDS.

3. MEDICATIONS AND ART



ART (antiretroviral therapy) is the medications used to treat HIV. ART helps the body to stop the virus (HIV) in the body and protects the immune system.⁸



Taking ART consistently can make HIV untransmittable.

U=U means:
Undetectable = Untransmittable.

When HIV is undetectable in the body, it cannot be passed to sexual partners.⁹



Older adults should talk with doctors or pharmacists about drug interactions with medications for blood pressure, diabetes, cholesterol, and other conditions.¹⁰



Do not stop, skip, or change ART without medical advice, even if you feel well.



KEY MESSAGE: ART works best when taken every day and reviewed regularly with a healthcare provider.



4. WHY STAYING ON ART MATTERS

46%

developed AIDS within 10 years without ART.¹¹



82%

ART adherence was needed to achieve viral suppression in 90% of viral load tests.¹²



5. LOOKING FOR ACCESSIBLE HEALTHCARE AND SUPPORT?



Community organizations can help:¹³

- Medication support
- Counselling
- Referrals to doctors
- Peer support
- Local resources



PWA Toronto¹⁴¹⁵

Provider of treatment and wrap-around care services.

(416) 506-1400

References



Scan the QR code to access HIV resources and references.